

Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

BLASE: Rajnath Singh with Raje



Fighting a Lone Battle

With the state polls exactly a year away, detractors in the state BJP threaten to play spoilsport as the party top brass chooses to play safe and Raje fails to nip dissent in the bud

■ **By Rohit Parihar**

It was not the kind of welcome that party stalwart Lal Krishna Advani is accustomed to on his tours across the country. When he arrived in Sanwaliaji, a pilgrim centre in Rajasthan's Chittorgarh district last week to attend the executive committee meeting of the state BJP, several powerful local party leaders boycotted the meeting. This was a calculated act of defiance at a time when the visit was aimed at launching the party's campaign for the Assembly elections due late next year.

If Advani was attempting to portray a united face of the faction-ridden state unit through this visit, then his mere declaration that Chief Minister

Vasundhara Raje would lead the party into the next polls in the state did not really serve the purpose. He talked obliquely against dissidence and said, "Infighting can make a party lose the gains of good works," but refrained from spelling out any decisive action against the absentees at the meeting which included six Cabinet ministers, 18 of the 38 district presidents, 27 of the 123 MLAs and 17 of the 27 MPs. The intent was there but the resolve was missing. He reminded the workers that the party had sacked six of its eight MLAs in the state on grounds of indiscipline once, but that was as far as he went. Gopi Nath Munde, BJP vice-president, in charge of the party in the state, sang peans to Raje, but did not speak a word about the rebels.

This then is the real problem of Raje, who is having to face dissent from within her party at a time when the Opposition Congress is charged up following a restructuring. C.P. Joshi has been installed as the new state Congress chief, Hema Ram has become the state legislative leader and Parasram Mordia has been made the working president, assisting former chief minister Ashok Gehlot.

Among the BJP's breakaway faction are ministers who enjoy powers without responsibilities and even go to the extent of boycotting party and cabinet meetings. Ironically, most dissidents are those who had targeted Bhairon Singh Shekhawat too when he was chief minister in the 1990s. Raje's quest for independence saw her